Sales Insights Report — Sample Superstore

ApexLark Data Analytics Internship · Day 01 · Prepared in Microsoft Excel

1. Dataset Overview

9,994 order line items × 19 columns covering US retail sales from Jan 2014 to Dec 2017: 5,009 orders, 793 customers, 531 cities, 4 regions, 3 categories and 17 sub-categories. Column types: Text (Order/Customer/Product IDs, location, category fields), Date (Order and Ship Date), Number (Row ID, Quantity, Discount) and Currency (Sales, Profit). There are no Boolean columns.

2. Data Quality Observations

• **No missing values** (0 blank cells) and no duplicate Row IDs.
• **1 duplicate record** (Row IDs 3406/3407 identical on every other field). It is flagged in yellow for review.
• **Inconsistent date formats:** 5,952 order dates used "/" while the rest used "-" (MM-DD-YYYY vs M/D/YYYY). All were converted to true Excel dates, and no ship date precedes its order date.
• **Text formatting:** 16 product names had trailing spaces, which were trimmed.
• **1,871 line items (18.7%) were sold at a loss.** They are valid but highlighted in orange. Sales, quantity and discount values were all within valid ranges.

3. Key Business Metrics

Total Sales	$2,297,201	**Total Profit**	$286,397 (12.5% margin)
Total Quantity	37,873 units	**Avg Order Value**	$458.61
Highest Sale	$22,638.48	**Lowest Sale**	$0.44
Unique Customers	793	**Categories**	3

4. Key Findings

• **Technology is the top category** with $836K in sales (36%), ahead of Furniture ($742K) and Office Supplies ($719K).
• **Furniture earns little profit:** only $18K, a 2.5% margin, compared with roughly 17% for Technology and Office Supplies.
• **New York City generates the most revenue** ($256K), followed by Los Angeles, Seattle and San Francisco. The West and East regions bring in 61% of sales.
• **Highest-value order:** customer SM-20320, order CA-2014-145317, worth $23,661.
• **Sales are seasonal:** November 2017 was the best month ($118K), and the Sep–Dec period peaks every year.
• **Most units sold:** "Staples" (215 units). Profit falls sharply when discounts exceed 20%.

5. Recommendations for Management

• **Fix Furniture profitability:** review deep discounts on Tables and Bookcases, which lose money, and cap discounts at about 20%.
• **Invest behind Technology and the peak season:** build inventory and run marketing in Sep–Dec, and focus on the top cities (NYC, LA, Seattle).
• **Improve data entry standards:** enforce one date format and trimmed text at the source, and add a duplicate check so reporting stays reliable.